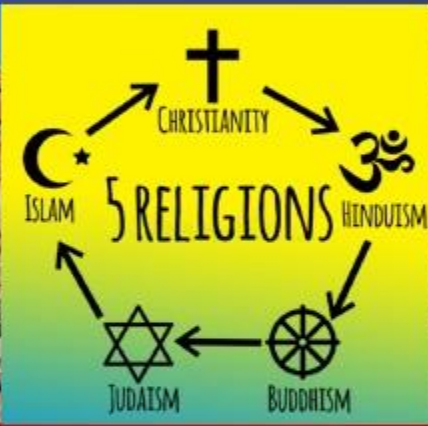


ART & CULTURE



INDIAN PAINTINGS

MODULE - 1

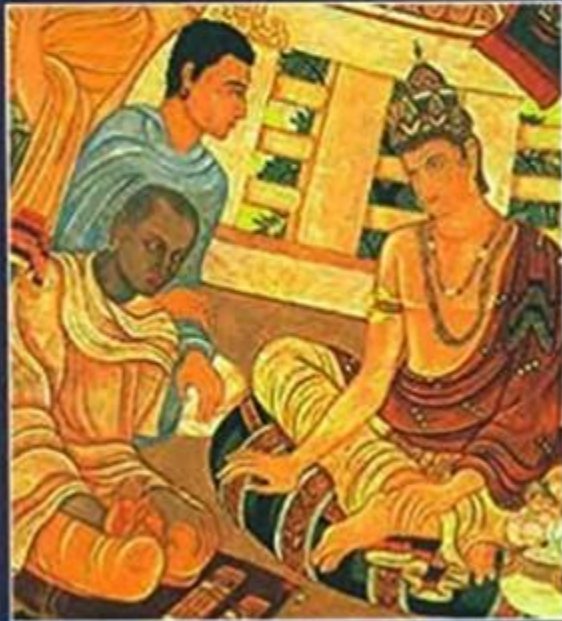
**PRINCIPLES OF
INDIAN PAINTINGS**

INTRODUCTION

- 1** India has a long tradition of artistic excellence and painting is one of the major mediums that have been used to express it.
- 2** There are several evidences that suggest that painting flourished in India since ancient times.
- 3** Archaeologists have found wall paintings in parts of India, which suggest that even the early historic man in India was engaged in activities of art and leisure.
- 4** The history of painting can be traced through the ancient and medieval period where the books were illustrated with paintings.
- 5** Then came the miniature style that dominated the Mughal and Rajput courts.
- 6** With the coming of the Europeans the art of painting and engraving took a western turn.
- 7** Modern painters experimented with styles, colours and designs.
- 8** Many Indian painters have gained worldwide recognition and are winning prizes and accolades for their vision.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

Mudrārākshasa of Viśākhadatta



- 1 The history of paintings can be known from primitive rock paintings of Bhimbetaka, Mirzapur and Panchmarhi.
- 2 They were followed by the painted pottery of the Indus Valley civilisation, but the real beginning of the art of paintings began from the Gupta Age.
- 3 It is during the fourth century that Vishakhadutta wrote his famous Sanskrit play Mudrarakshasa that made mention of many paintings.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

4 The text also mentioned the 6 main principles/limbs or **shadangas of painting** as:

Variety of form	Rupabheda
Portrayal of likeliness of the subject	Sadrisyam
Creation of luster and gleam with the colours	Bhava
Mixing of colours to resemble the effects of modelling	Varnikabhanga
Proportion of the object or subject	Pramanam
Immersion of emotions	Lavanyayoganam

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

- 5 There are numerous reference to art of painting in the Brahmanical and Buddhist literature, for example, the representation of the **myths and lore's on textiles that is known as Lepya Chitra.**



LEPYA CHITRA

- 6 We also find references to the art of **Lekhya Chitra, which has line drawings and sketches.** Other types are Dhuli Chitra, Pata Chitra, etc.
- 7 The play, Mudrarakshasa, also facilitated the reader by mentioning the name of various paintings or patas, which are important to understand the different styles of paintings and to observe all the principles of paintings. Some of the styles were:

Styles of Paintings	Major features
Cauka Pitaka	Isolated framed drawings
Dighala Pitaka	Long scrolls of paintings
Yama Pitaka	Isolated paintings

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

- 1** Painting- Alekhyam occupies the fourth place among the 64 Arts enumerated by Vatsyayana in his Kama Sutra.
- 2** While concluding, Vatsyayana has written a Shloka which amply indicated that painting was fully developed during that period and the six limbs of Painting (Shadangas) enumerated in the Kama Sutra were already in vogue.
- 3** 'Shadang' or the six limbs of Indian Art find their first mention in Vatsyayana's celebrated text Kama Sutra. Shadang weaves the language of an art work.
- 4** It defines the principles of creation of an artwork. It mirrors the limbs of art, without which an art work is deficient.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

*“Roopabhedah pramanani bhava-lavanya-yojanam |
Sadrishyam varnakabhangam iti chitram shadakam ||”*



SHADANGAS

1 This Shloka enumerates the six limbs of Indian Art- Rupa-bheda (secrets of form), pramanani (proportion), bhava (emotional Disposition), lavanya-yojanam (gracefulness in composition), sadrisyam (‘similitude’) and varnika-bhanga (colour differentiation).

2 The following principles explicate the theory of traditional Indian painting.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

RUPA-BHEDA

PRINCIPLE NO. 1



- 1 Rupa-bheda presupposes accurate draughtsmanship and the importance of Form.
- 2 It stresses on the Physical typologies of form.
- 3 It not only stresses on the knowledge of form (Rupa) but also on the subtle and stark difference of forms.
- 4 For instance a work must be articulate enough to let the ordinary eye decipher between a dead man and a sleeping man.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

PRAMANAM

PRINCIPLE NO. 2



- 1 The manifestation of form must be guarded by the power of Pramanani (proportion).
- 2 It emphasises on perception, measurement and structure.
- 3 It provides an insight into the structural anatomy of objects.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

BHAVA

PRINCIPLE NO. 3

- 1 Bhavayojana speaks about the emotion, a feeling or an intention.



- 2 It eulogizes the expression of emotions- the formless. Bhava are of two types, covert i.e. the hidden emotions and overt i.e. revealed emotions.
- 3 Celebrated Indian artist Ravi Varma is particularly noted for his paintings that most delicately depict the veiled emotions.
- 4 One of his most famous paintings show Shakuntala, who pretends to remove a thorn from her foot, while actually looking for Dushyantha, as her friends call her bluff.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

LAVANYA-YOJANAM

PRINCIPLE NO. 4



- 1 Lavanya, an extremely essential limb of Indian art stands for 'Grace'.
- 2 Its importance can be illustrated through the example of a meal/curry rich in all flavours and spices save the salt.
- 3 Just as the curry loses its charm without the salt, so does a painting without lavanya.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

LAVANYA-YOJANAM

PRINCIPLE NO. 4



4 The Indian Yakshi sculptures at Kajhurahe and Konark are a hallmark of Lavanya. Here the Yakshi of Didarganj deserves a special mention for its unparalleled beauty and poise.

5 This life size statue is one of the most remarkable pieces of Mauryan art.

6 It is an ideal example where its creator has truly infused grace in her beauty.

7 Lavanya blooms in the bodily postures, bhaav- bhangima and of course in the ornaments and robes that add to the beauty of bodily contours.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

LAVANYA-YOJANAM

PRINCIPLE NO. 4



8 Another striking example of Lavanya is the sculpture at Sun temple Konark, of a heavenly nymph writing a love letter.

9 One can experience the fragrance of grace in every visual modulation of her inner love, be it the posture, the expressive eyes or the way she holds the pen and the pad.

10 An artist cannot justify a character unless this grace is achieved for it is this lavanya that enables him to show the beauty that resides not in appearance but essence.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

SADRISHYAM

PRINCIPLE NO. 5

- 1** Sadrishyam means Similitude. An artist strives to achieve similitude in his creation.
- 2** Sometimes he derives this similitude from the forms, sometimes from the attributes and sometimes from the virtues.
- 3** In Chitrasutra of Vhishnudharmottara purana there is a mention of 5 types of eyes that have sadrishyam in the forms like fish, conch, lotus petals etc.
- 4** In Indian poetry, just as in Indian painting, the black lustrous curly locks of a woman are compared with the snake or dark clouds.
- 5** Even in the asanas like the bhujang asana, mayur asana and lotus asana one find sadrishyam of certain animal postures.

PRINCIPLES OF PAINTINGS

SHADANGAS

VARNIKA-BHANGA

PRINCIPLE NO. 6

1 This limb pertains to 'colour' that lends soul to an artwork.

2 The beauty of colour is not in the colour but in its application.

3 A master painter magnifies the splendour of different shades on the surface with the strength of the stroke of his brush.

4 The myriad hues are not only an aspect of appearance but are the expression of inner character.

5 In the hands of a versatile artist even ordinary colours pronounces extraordinary exuberance.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

- 1 The pre-historic paintings were generally executed on rocks and these rock engravings were called Petroglyphs.



BHIMBETAKA PAINTINGS

- 2 The first set of pre-historic paintings was discovered in Bhimbetaka caves in Madhya Pradesh.
- 3 The Bhimbetaka paintings were discovered in 1957-58 by an archaeologist named V.S Wakankar.
- 4 These paintings are generally depicting animals like bison and tigers etc.
- 5 They have been called the 'Zoo Rock Shelter' because it depicts elephant, rhinoceros, cattle, snake, spotted deer, barasingha, etc.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

There are three major phases of pre-historic paintings:

UPPER PALEOLITHIC PERIOD



- 1 The walls of the rock shelter caves are made of **quartzite walls** and so they used minerals for pigments.
- 2 One of the most common minerals was **ochre** or **geru** mixed with **lime** and **water**.
- 3 They used different minerals to make colours like red, white, yellow and green, which widened their palette.
- 4 The **white**, **dark red** and **green** were used to depict **large animals** like bison, elephant, rhino, tigers etc. For the **human figurines** the **red** was used for hunters and the **green** mostly for the **dancers**.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

MESOLITHIC PERIOD



- 1 This period mainly sees the use of red colour.
- 2 In comparison to the Upper Paleolithic period, the size of the paintings also became smaller during this period.
- 3 One of the most common scenes depicted in these paintings is of group hunting and several paintings depict grazing activity and riding scenes.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

MESOLITHIC PERIOD

1

Mesolithic rock cut architecture of India not only reflects the cultural life of the times but also a fine aesthetic sense comparable to modern painting. Critically evaluate this comment.

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PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

CHALCOLITHIC PERIOD



- 1 This period saw the increase in the number of paintings using the green and yellow colour.
- 2 Most of the paintings concentrate on depicting battle scenes.
- 3 There are many paintings of men riding horses and elephants.
- 4 Some of them even carry bow and arrow which might indicate preparedness for skirmishes.
- 5 We know that these cave sites were inhabited in the late historical periods as we have paintings and samples of writing in the Ashokan and Gupta Brahmi scripts.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

CHALCOLITHIC PERIOD



- 6 The other set of paintings from the Mesolithic period are in **Narsingarh in Madhya Pradesh**.
- 7 They have paintings to show **skins of spotted deer** left for drying that provides credence to the theory that the art of **tanning skins was perfected by man** for providing clothing shelter.
- 8 Other paintings from this period also have depictions of **musical instruments like the harp**.
- 9 Some of the paintings have **complex geometrical shapes** like the spiral, rhomboid and circle.

PRE-HISTORIC PAINTINGS

CHALCOLITHIC PERIOD

- 10** Some of the paintings from the later period can be seen in the **Jogimara caves in the Ramgarh hills in Sarguja district of Chhattisgarh**. These are dated to be painted around 100 BCE.
- 12** Chhattisgarh is also home to the variety of caves in the district of Kanker like the shelter of Udkuda, Garagodi, Khairkheda, Gotitola, Kulgaon, etc.
- 13** These shelters depict the **human figurines, animals, palm prints, bullock carts, etc** which shows a higher sedentary level of living.
- 14** Similar paintings can be seen in the Ghodsar and Kohabaur rock art sites in the district of Koriya.
- 15** Another interesting site is in Chitwa Dongri (Durg district) where we find a **Chinese figure riding a donkey, pictures of dragons and agricultural sceneries**.
- 16** Several interesting rock paintings have also been found in Limdariha in Bastar districts and Oogdi, Sitalekhni in Sarguja district.

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